**SIUE Pulls Away Late to Defeat Tennessee State**

**Cougars Overcome Halftime Deficit to Earn Key OVC Victory**

**by Jevion Guthrie**

**February 20, 2025**

**Edwardsville** - SIUE men's basketball team found themselves trailing midway through the first half, 22-29, before  clawing their way back. Even While trailing the team was energized on defense, and earned some key stops down the stretch.

At the half, the squad cut the deficit to one, making the score 39-40 before the next half began.

"I just lace up and genuinely just want to be able to put myself in that position to go out there and execute the task at hand" says guard Brian Taylor. " I know the other four people are ready to do the same."

Taylor led all scorers with 22 points shooting a perfect,10-10 from the free throw line as well as adding eight rebounds and recording two steals on the defensive end.

**Second-Half Surge Lifts Cougars**

To begin the 2nnd half, Tennessee State controlled the tempo early, knocking down key shots and forcing turnovers.

TSU was not the only team on the court that figured it out coming into the half. The Cougars ramped up the defense and strung together some stops as well.

The Cougars responded to the Tigers by outscoring them 45–32 after the break. Defensive pressure led to transition baskets, and SIUE capitalized on second-chance opportunities.

“I think one of the biggest things is us being self aware…I think we caught onto what's working and we just stuck with it.” Said Taylor.

Arnas Sakenis, Jr center, Came off of the bench and provided a spark on defense. He only had 3 points and 2 rebounds but he was an anchor in the paint recording 5 blocks.

While Sakenis Was securing the paint, Ray’Sean Taylor was on the perimeter locking up, recording 4 steals.

The senior guard was not only locked in on defense, but he was focused on the offensive end as well, recording 15 points and 8 assist as the primary ball handler for the squad.

The win keeps SIUE in the hunt for a top seed in the OVC Tournament. With only a few games remaining in the regular season, every result matters. The Cougars, now 18–9 overall and 11–5 in the Ohio Valley Conference, bounced back after a tough loss to UT Martin earlier in the week.